

Experiments provide a more accurate gauge. What could we see in real time that would serve as a proxy for the value participants were gaining from volunteering? We could find opportunities for a small number of employees to volunteer and then look at the retention rate of those employees. How many of them sign up to volunteer again? When an employee voluntarily invests their time and attention in this program, that is a strong indicator that they find it valuable.

For the growth hypothesis, which tests how new customers will discover a product or service, we can do a similar analysis. Once the program is up and running, how will it spread among the employees, from initial early adopters to mass adoption throughout the company? A likely way this program could expand is through viral growth. If that is true, the most important thing to measure is behavior: would the early participants actively spread the word to other employees?

In this case, a simple experiment would involve taking a very small number—a dozen, perhaps—of existing long-term employees and providing an exceptional volunteer opportunity for them. Because Caroline's hypothesis was that employees would be motivated by their desire to live up to HP's historical commitment to community service, the experiment would target employees who felt the greatest sense of disconnect between their daily routine and the company's expressed values. The point is not to find the average customer but to find early adopters: the customers who feel the need for the product most acutely. Those customers tend to be more forgiving of mistakes and are especially eager to give feedback.

Next, using a technique I call the concierge minimum viable product (described in detail in [Chapter 6](#)), Caroline could make sure the first few participants had an experience that was as good as she could make it, completely aligned with her vision. Unlike in a focus group, her goal would be to measure what the customers actually did. For example, how many of the first volunteers actually complete their volunteer assignments? How many volunteer a second time? How many are willing to recruit a colleague to